PRODUCTIZE AND SCALE

Turning a service business into something that runs without you.
Eight steps, each ending in something you have to write down.
Finish it and you have your own plan, not mine.

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EVERYTHING HERE COST ME MONEY TO LEARN

In May 2015 I founded division5 in Albania. I was 23, with no connections, no money, no references and no experience. Demand eventually outran what we could deliver, we had to hire, and every year after that the thing blocking the company turned out to be something that existed only in my head.

> **THOUSANDS**
>
> of jobs created for young Albanians since then, in a country losing its best people to emigration faster than it can replace them.

A service business does not stall because the work is bad. It stalls because the work is different every time, so nothing compounds. Every new client resets you to the blank page, and the only thing that scales is the number of hours you personally sell.

Productizing is the fix, and it has an order. Most founders start at the end, buying software to automate a process nobody has written down. That makes the mess run faster. This is the order that works.

How to use it

Eight steps. Each ends with something to compile. Answer them in your head and you will flatter yourself through every one, so give it an afternoon and something to write on. The finished document is the point.

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY SELL

Ask a founder what their company does and you get a category. Ask what they sold last month and you get a list of favours. The gap between those two answers is where the margin went.

Productizing does not start with inventing an offer. It starts with noticing which one you have already sold more than once, because that is the one the market has already voted for. Almost every service business has one and cannot see it, because repetition feels like the boring work rather than the valuable work.

The test: if your second client costs materially less to serve than your first, that offer is productized. If every engagement starts from a blank page, it is not.

COMPILE

List the three things you sold most often in the last twelve months. For each one, write the scope in a single sentence, and mark how much of the work was identical to the time before.

M mostly the same **H** half the same **N** new every time

WHO PAYS, AND FROM WHERE

Revenue tells you the business works. Where it comes from tells you whether it can grow. A company selling only into its own city has a ceiling set by that city, and no amount of process fixes that.

This step is uncomfortable because it is usually the first time the concentration becomes visible. Most service businesses discover that a small number of clients are most of the revenue, and that the pipeline that produced them was one person's network.

Neither is a disaster. Both are things you can only fix once you have written them down.

COMPILE

Your last ten customers. For each: country, what they bought, what they paid, and how they found you. Pull it from your records, not from memory.

Then two numbers. What share of revenue is your largest client? What share comes from outside your own country?

HOW THE WORK REALLY HAPPENS

Every company has two processes. The one in the proposal, and the one people actually follow, which includes the workarounds nobody puts in writing because they feel like admissions.

The second one is the real asset. It is also the one that lives in people's heads, which is why the business cannot grow past the number of heads that hold it, and why every new hire takes six months to become useful.

Do not write the tidy version. The tidy version is what you already have, and it has never helped anyone deliver anything.

COMPILE

Take your most repeated offer and map it end to end: every step from first contact to final invoice. Mark each step with who does it and how long it takes.

Then mark every step that depends on one specific person knowing something that is written down nowhere. Those marks are your fragility, in order.

WHERE THE WORK COMES FROM

Ask most service founders how they get clients and the honest answer is referrals and luck. Referrals are wonderful and they are not a channel, because you cannot turn them up when you need to. A business whose only source of work is other people remembering it exists is not in control of its own growth.

This is the step most founders skip, and it is the one that decides whether productizing was worth doing at all. A repeatable offer with an unrepeatable pipeline is just a tidier version of the same problem.

The question is not which channel is best. It is which one you have actual evidence for.

COMPILE

For the same ten customers, write where each one genuinely originated. Not the last touch. The first.

Then pick the single channel with the most evidence behind it and write one sentence on what doing three times as much of it would require.

WHAT ONLY YOU CAN DO

Every service business has one constraint everything else queues behind, and in most of them it is the founder. This is not a character flaw. It is what happens when a company grows out of one person being good at something.

The test is not how busy you are, because busy is easy to mistake for essential. The test is **what stops when you stop.**

Sorting the answer matters more than the answer. Work that needs your context can be documented. Work that needs your authority can be delegated the day you decide to. Only the third kind is genuinely yours, and it is always a much shorter list than it feels like at four in the afternoon.

COMPILE

For one week, log every decision that came to you, as it happens. Not from memory at the end.

Then mark each one:

C only you had the context **A** only you had the authority **S** only you had the skill

ONE CLEAN VERSION OF YOUR NUMBERS

By this point you have written down what you sell, who buys it, how it gets delivered and where it comes from. The next question is where each of those lives, and the answer is usually: four places, disagreeing.

This is the step that gates everything after it. You cannot automate a process whose data is scattered across a spreadsheet, an inbox, a project tool and somebody's memory, because the automation has nothing reliable to read. Every attempt to skip this produces software that is technically working and practically ignored.

One version of each thing. Customers, projects, money, people. Not one tool necessarily, but one authoritative source per thing, and everyone agreeing which it is.

COMPILE

Four rows: customers, projects, invoices, people. For each, write where the truth lives today, and who would notice first if it were wrong.

Any row where you named more than one place is a row that will break the next step.

ONLY NOW, AUTOMATE

Six steps in, you know which offer repeats, how it is delivered, where the work comes from and where the data lives. That is what a system gets built around. Add AI to it in two layers, in this order.

01 **Agents that propose**

They read, draft and suggest: the first reply, the summary, the sorted list. A person approves before anything reaches a client.

02 **Workflows that act**

Only for steps that follow a fixed rule every time. These run with nobody watching, so they are the last thing you add, not the first.

> **85%+**
>
> of division5's processes ran this way within a year of starting in late 2025. Before that, people did all of it. Improving a process went from months to weeks.

It is not easy. Agents that do the job well at a low cost are hard to build. Trusting one to act as you is harder. And the balance never settles: too much AI and mistakes reach the client, too little and people quietly do the work themselves.
The rule that holds it together: AI proposes, a person decides.

COMPILE

Take one process from step three. Mark what an agent could draft or propose, and what a workflow could run on a fixed rule. Beside each, write the data it needs and where it lives according to step six. If any of it is missing, that is the next task, not the automation.

THE NEXT NINETY DAYS

You now have eight sheets of paper describing your own company more honestly than any deck you have ever made. The temptation is to fix all of it. Resist that, because a plan with nine priorities has none.

One constraint. One process. One source of work that is not referral. Everything else waits, and waiting is a decision you make once rather than a thing that happens to you.

Ninety days is long enough to finish something and short enough that you cannot postpone starting. Put owners against each item, and make them people rather than departments.

Then do it again. A business with AI inside it is never finished. The system needs upkeep and steady tuning to keep giving good results at a cost that makes sense, so the end of these ninety days is where the next ninety start.

COMPILE

Three lines, and no more than three.

The one constraint I am removing. The one process I am productizing. The one channel I am building. An owner and a date beside each.

FOUR WAYS I CAN BE USEFUL

Everything above is the work. If you would rather not do all of it alone, these are the doors, and they are deliberately different sizes.

The AI Integration Sprint

Four remote sessions over two weeks with you and the people who actually run the business. For a service business it starts with productizing what you sell, then puts AI in the order step seven describes. You leave with the plan written.

division5

When the constraint is people. Vetted AI-native engineers from across the Balkans, working with companies in Europe and beyond.

divisionAI

When the constraint is that the business runs on people remembering things. One system built around your data and shaped to your processes, with the automation added in the order step seven describes.

Investment

If you are built in Albania or Kosovo, selling to paying customers in Europe or the US, and productized enough that this playbook was mostly confirmation, I invest in companies like yours. Customers, distribution and the systems above come with it.

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